City of Cambridge

POR 2026-171
FIRST IN COUNCIL
September 14, 2026

MAYOR SIDDIQUI
COUNCILLOR AL-ZUBI
COUNCILLOR MCGOVERN
VICE MAYOR AZEEM

WHEREAS: The Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) is the largest and most effective anti-hunger assistance program in the nation, serving over 895,000 Massachusetts recipients or 561,000 Massachusetts households in June 2026, and approximately 10,000 individuals in Cambridge in July 2025; and

WHEREAS: The monthly number of calls from individuals needing action from the Department of Transitional Assistance (DTA) to receive or keep SNAP but were unable to connect to a call center representative reached a record high in March 2026 of 11,806, likely due to insufficient staff to answer phone lines; and

WHEREAS: In July 2025, President Trump signed H.R.1 ("One Big Beautiful Bill") into law, resulting in a decrease of approximately 180,000 Massachusetts recipients of SNAP benefits, including 63,000 children; and

WHEREAS: Since July 2025, the number of monthly walk-in visits for those seeking services has remained constant, but the average number of processing days for new SNAP applications has increased from 11 days to 21 days; and

WHEREAS: According to the Massachusetts Law Reform Institute (MLRI), the Cambridge economy has already lost approximately $2.95 million in annualized federal SNAP dollars, with approximately $28.8 million in annualized federal MassHealth dollars at risk; and

WHEREAS: Since July 2025, Cambridge's SNAP enrollment has fallen by 15.2%, or 1,491 residents, and according to the MLRI, 70% of application denials and 50% of recertifications were denied for procedural reasons; and

WHEREAS: While the Federal government is focused on cutting programs that have served our residents well for decades, the Commonwealth of Massachusetts can choose to invest in SNAP and DTA's workforce; now therefore be it

RESOLVED: That the City Council urge the Healey-Driscoll Administration and the Massachusetts General Court to prioritize the hiring of additional DTA case workers to ensure those eligible for SNAP are able to receive and maintain benefits and taking other steps needed to end the SNAP access crisis; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Clerk be and hereby is requested to forward suitably

engrossed copies of this resolution to Governor Maura Healey, DTA Commissioner Michael Cole, and the Cambridge state legislative delegation on behalf of the entire City Council.

A true copy;

ATTEST:-

Paula M. Crane,
Interim City Clerk

City of Cambridge

That the City Council urge the Healey-Driscoll Administration and the Massachusetts General Court to prioritize the hiring of additional DTA case workers to ensure those eligible for SNAP are able to receive and maintain benefits and taking other steps needed to end the SNAP access crisis.